

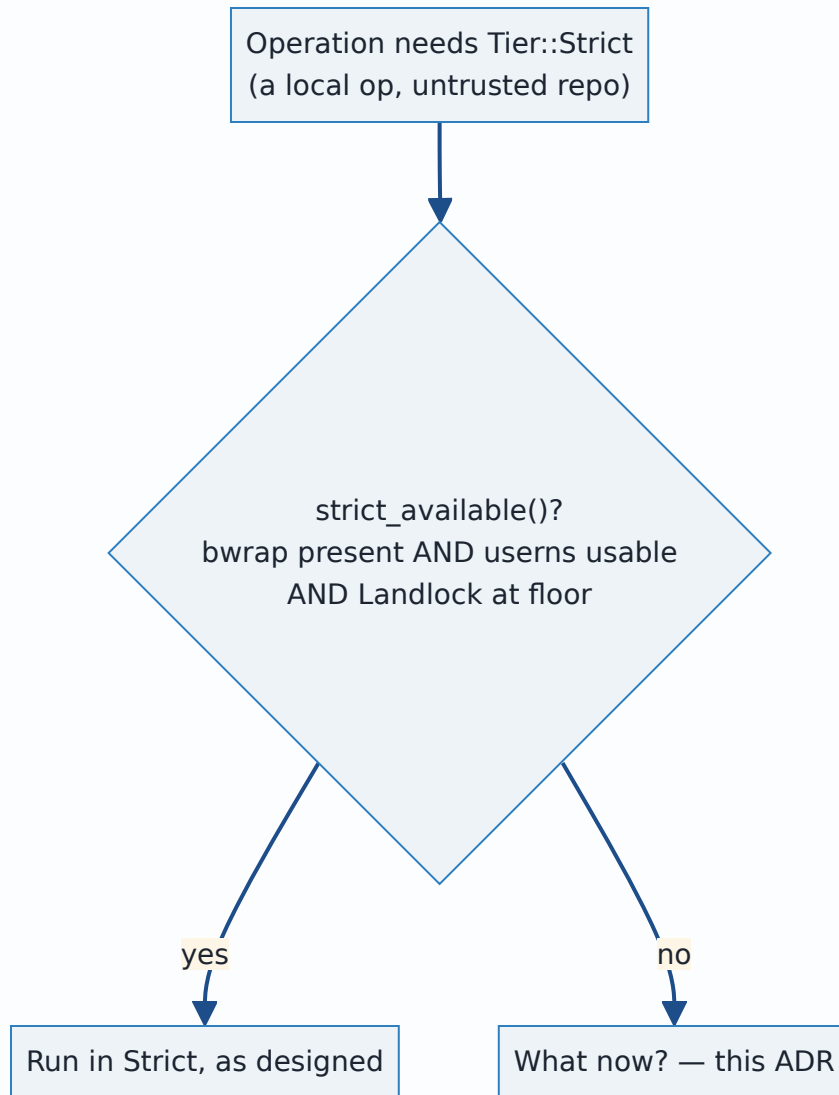
0029 — INV-13: hard-fail when the Strict tier is selected but unavailable

- **Status:** Accepted — implementation pending
- **Date:** 2026-07-29
- **Milestone / issue:** M1.13b — the Git-process sandbox (#66). Resolves INV-13, which the escape-battery anti-vacuity contract's ordered-work step 7 listed as "BLOCKED ON TOM — not an agent's call" ([design-docs/2026-07-29-escape-battery-anti-vacuity-contract.md](#)). Load-bearing for plan Tasks 8, 9 and 16 ([docs/superpowers/plans/2026-07-28-m1.13b-sandbox.md](#)), none of which have landed as of this ADR.
- **Supersedes:** nothing directly — this is the first ADR to state INV-13 as a decision rather than an open question. **Amends:** plan Task 16's current text for `hook_policy_for_repo`, which maps `CapabilityAbsent` to `HookPolicy::Blocked` — see "Where the plan still disagrees with this ADR," below.
- **Related:** [0027](#) and [0028](#) (the same "say plainly what is and is not true of the code" discipline, applied here to a capability- detection claim instead of a filesystem or network one); [0025](#) (hook policy as a declared, disclosed value — the same framing this ADR extends to capability refusal); [docs/superpowers/evidence/2026-07-29-m1.13b-codex-C12-tier-dispatch-audit.md](#) (the audit that forced this ADR to say more than the one-line decision).

Context

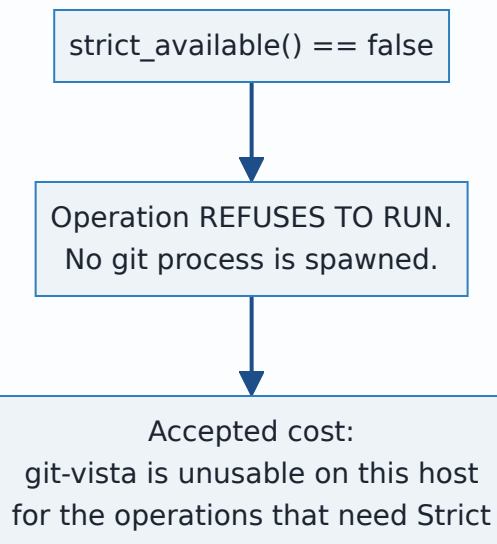
The M1.13b sandbox has three tiers. Strict (bwrap namespaces plus Landlock plus seccomp) is the tier local operations on untrusted repositories run in — no network, fullest isolation. Network (Landlock only, TCP allowed on enumerated ports) is what remote operations need, because a network namespace breaks DNS resolution for `push / fetch / clone` (the round-4 verdict's F3). `Capabilities::strict_available()` ([crates/git-vista-server/src/sandbox/capabilities.rs:47-53](#)) measures whether a host can actually provide Strict: Landlock at the ABI floor, a `bwrap` binary found at an absolute reviewed path, and usable unprivileged user namespaces — all three, because Strict's isolation is a *composition* and a missing piece is not a weaker Strict tier, it is a different, undeclared one.

Some hosts fail that check. The question this ADR answers: what does git-vista do, on such a host, for an operation that needs the Strict tier?



The decision, exactly as taken

INV-13 → HARD-FAIL. When the Strict tier is selected for an operation and `bwrap` or unprivileged user namespaces are unavailable on the host, the operation refuses to run. There is no degrade to the Network tier, and no degrade-and-block-hooks posture. This is now plan **Global Constraint 15** ([docs/superpowers/plans/2026-07-28-m1.13b-sandbox.md:93](#)). Tom accepted the cost in plain words: git-vista is unusable on a host without bubblewrap.



Alternatives considered, and why they lost

Degrade Strict to Network

Rejected. Strict is selected precisely for local operations on untrusted repositories, and Network grants TCP egress on enumerated ports (`DEFAULT_GIT_PORTS` , `crates/git-vista-server/src/sandbox/mod.rs`). Degrading would hand network access to exactly the operations the tier exists to keep off the network — the best-effort security downgrade Global Constraint 1 (C5) forbids: *"silently applying a weaker best-effort policy is incompatible with any stated claim."* A silent downgrade under host variation is the failure mode this whole milestone exists to eliminate.

Degrade and block hooks

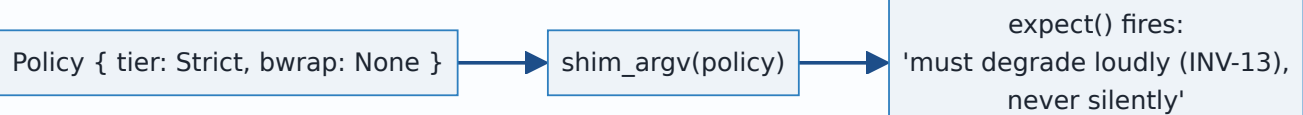
Rejected as an attempted middle path — run the operation in a weaker tier but suppress `.git/hooks/*` so the missing isolation cannot be exploited through a hook. This still degrades silently (a repository that asked for Strict gets a different, weaker tier without refusing), and it does not survive contact with the plan text: Task 16's `hook_policy_for_repo` (`docs/superpowers/plans/2026-07-28-m1.13b-sandbox.md:4915-4923`) currently maps `ProbeVerdict::CapabilityAbsent | ProbeVerdict::FailOpen` to `HookPolicy::Blocked` — **this is the rejected posture, still present in the plan.** The plan's own text at lines 3344-3352 already flags the contradiction: *"once boot enforces INV-13/GC15, only Contained reaches production... Task 16.6's `hook_policy_for_repo` maps `CapabilityAbsent | FailOpen` to `HookPolicy::Blocked` — a degrade-and-block-hooks posture Global Constraint 15 rejects by name."* Task 9's redesign has to remove that mapping; see "Where the plan still disagrees with this ADR," below.

Represent "Strict without bwrap" as a Policy value

Not available, and this is a useful consequence rather than a gap: `Policy` cannot express it. `shim_argv` (`crates/git-vista-server/src/sandbox/mod.rs`) panics if asked to:

```
// # Panics
//
// Never for `Tier::Unsandboxed` – both callers return before reaching here.
// Panics if a `Strict` policy carries no `bwrap` path; `Policy` construction
// is responsible for degrading to `Network` or reporting INV-13 instead of
// building a strict policy that cannot launch its own namespace boundary.
fn shim_argv(policy: &Policy) -> Vec<OsString> {
    ...
    if policy.tier == Tier::Strict {
        let bwrap = policy.bwrap.as_ref().expect(
            "a Strict policy must carry a resolved bwrap path; without namespaces it is \
            not the strict tier and must degrade loudly (INV-13), never silently",
        );
        ...
    }
}
```

Confirmed by direct read of the current source. The hard-fail needs no new type: the type system already refuses to build the degraded thing, and the `.expect()` message already cites INV-13 by name, ahead of Task 8 wiring tier dispatch to reach this path in production.



The complication: "hard-fail" as a slogan does not survive contact with the code

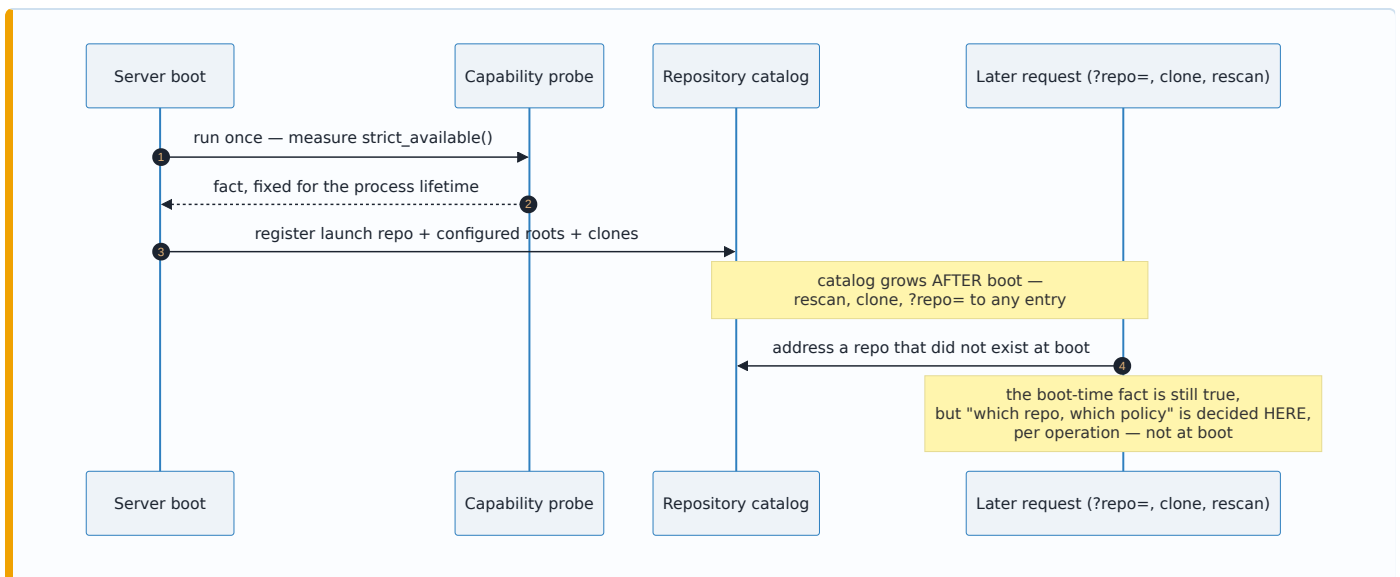
An independent audit — C12, `docs/superpowers/evidence/2026-07-29-m1.13b-codex-C12-tier-dispatch-audit.md` — reviewed the recovered design for INV-13 and refused to approve it unchanged for two structural reasons. Both were verified against current source for this ADR; nothing below is asserted without a file:line citation.

1. A boot gate cannot be total

The server is multi-repository and dynamic, not a single boot-time subject that a single capability check can stand in for:

- boot registers the launch repository, configured-root children, and persistent clones (`crates/git-vista-server/src/main.rs:134-164` , per the audit; not independently re-read line-for-line for this ADR, but consistent with the catalog design in ADR 0003/0009);
- reads can address **any** catalog entry via an opaque `?repo=` parameter (`crates/git-vista-server/src/handlers/read.rs` , per the audit);
- rescan adds repositories after launch (`crates/git-vista-server/src/handlers/select.rs` , per the audit);
- clone creates and registers a repository at runtime (`crates/git-vista-server/src/handlers/clone.rs` , per the audit);
- and `policy_for_repo` grants read-write to the *specific repo argument* passed to it (`crates/git-vista-server/src/sandbox/mod.rs:451-467` , confirmed by direct read for this ADR — `policy_for_repo(repo: &Path)` pushes `repo.to_path_buf()` into `rw_trees`).

One capability probe run once at boot answers "can this host provide Strict at all" — a fact that does not change between requests — but it cannot stand in for a per-operation, per-repository refusal, because the set of repositories the server will be asked to operate on is not fixed at boot.



Resolution this ADR adopts: keep the boot capability gate (a host that fails `strict_available()` when Strict is required at all should refuse to start rather than fail silently later — this is INV-13/Global Constraint 15's existing boot-gate half, plan Task 9), but pair it with a per-operation check: every call to `policy_for_repo` (or its Task-8 successor that actually dispatches tiers) must itself be able to refuse, for the repository and operation in front of it, not only rely on a fact established once at process start. A boot gate proves the host *can* supply Strict in principle; it cannot prove *this* operation, on *this* repository, right now, gets it — those are different questions, decided at different times, and conflating them is exactly the gap C12 named.

2. Failure is currently swallowed into wrong answers, not refusals

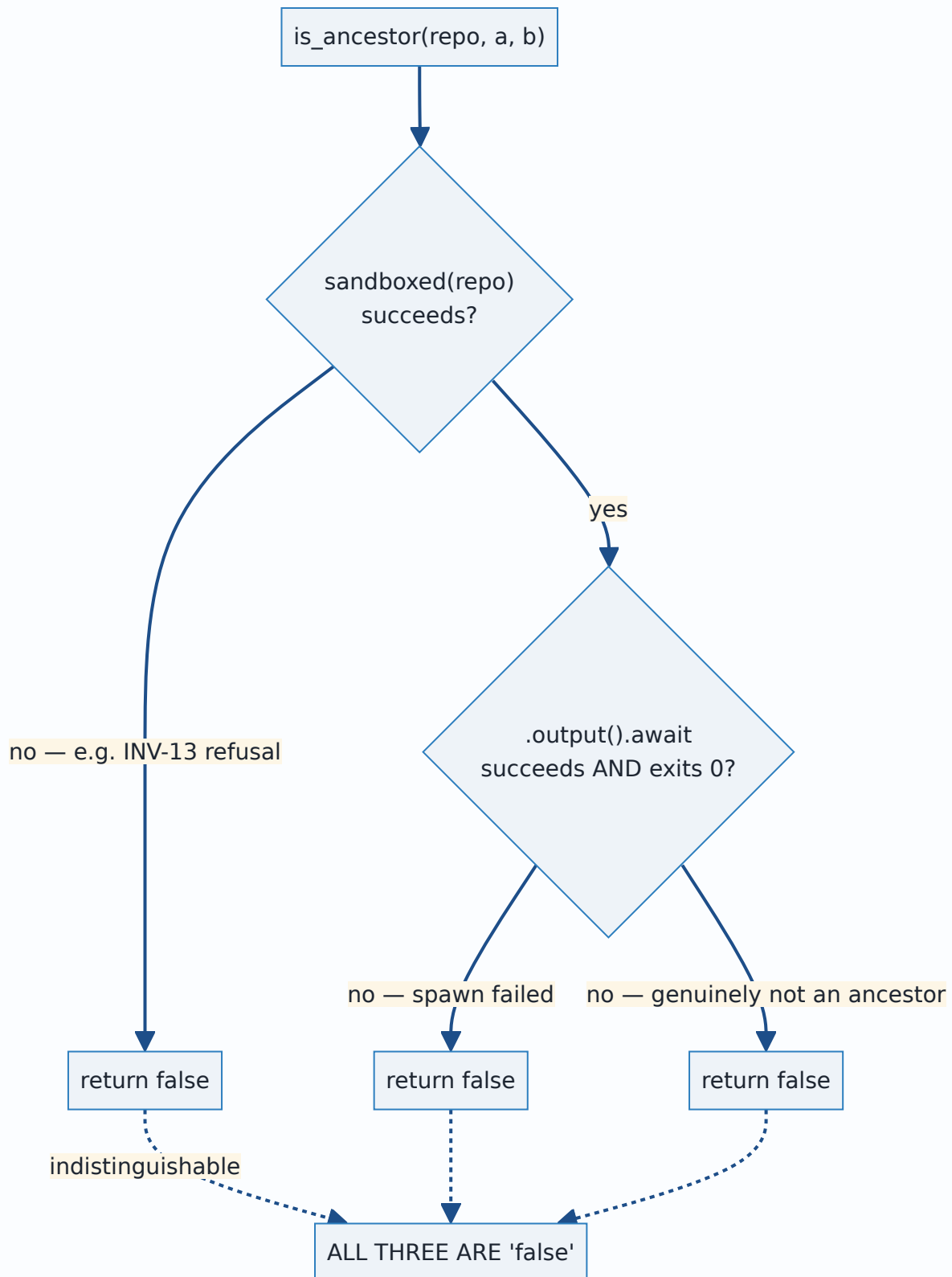
This is the sharper problem, because it means "hard-fail" is not merely unimplemented — the code that exists today does the *opposite* of failing hard in several places, and the sandbox would add a new way to reach an existing defect rather than invent a new one.

Verified directly against current source for this ADR (confirming C12's claims 1-3 and the coordinator/planner swallow sites):

git_cmd.rs collapses three distinct outcomes into one Boolean or one Option:

```
// crates/git-vista-server/src/git_cmd.rs:270-278
pub(crate) async fn is_ancestor(repo: &Path, ancestor: &str, rev: &str) -> bool {
    let Ok(mut cmd) = sandboxed(repo) else {
        return false;
    };
    cmd.args(["merge-base", "--is-ancestor", ancestor, rev])
        .output()
        .await
        .map(|o| o.status.success())
        .unwrap_or(false)
}
```

A genuine "not an ancestor," a policy-construction failure (which is exactly what a Strict-tier hard-fail would raise), and a spawn failure are all `false` here. `git_ref_exists` (`git_cmd.rs:303-314`) has the identical shape. `rev_parse` (`git_cmd.rs:247-264`) does the same into `Option<String>` via `.ok()? twice` — "ref absent" and "could not run git at all" are one `None` .



Both callers of these two functions live in the rebase live gate (`crates/git-vista-server/src/handlers/rebase.rs`). Verified: `git_ref_exists` at `rebase.rs:44` selects local `main` over `origin/main` when it returns `false` — indistinguishable from "the remote-tracking ref genuinely

doesn't exist." `is_ancestor` at `rebase.rs:59` feeds `up_to_date`, which leaves the rebase menu action enabled on failure (`crates/git-vista/src/menu.rs:578-607`) — failure does not execute a rebase automatically, but it does not refuse the UI action either, which a hard-fail invariant requires it to.

rev_parse has 20 production call sites (per C12's enumeration, spanning `handlers/rebase.rs`, `handlers/commit.rs`, `activity.rs`, and roughly a dozen sites in `planner.rs`) with genuinely different failure semantics. Two are safety-relevant in ways worth restating here because they are the starkest evidence that "just propagate the error" is not a one-line fix:

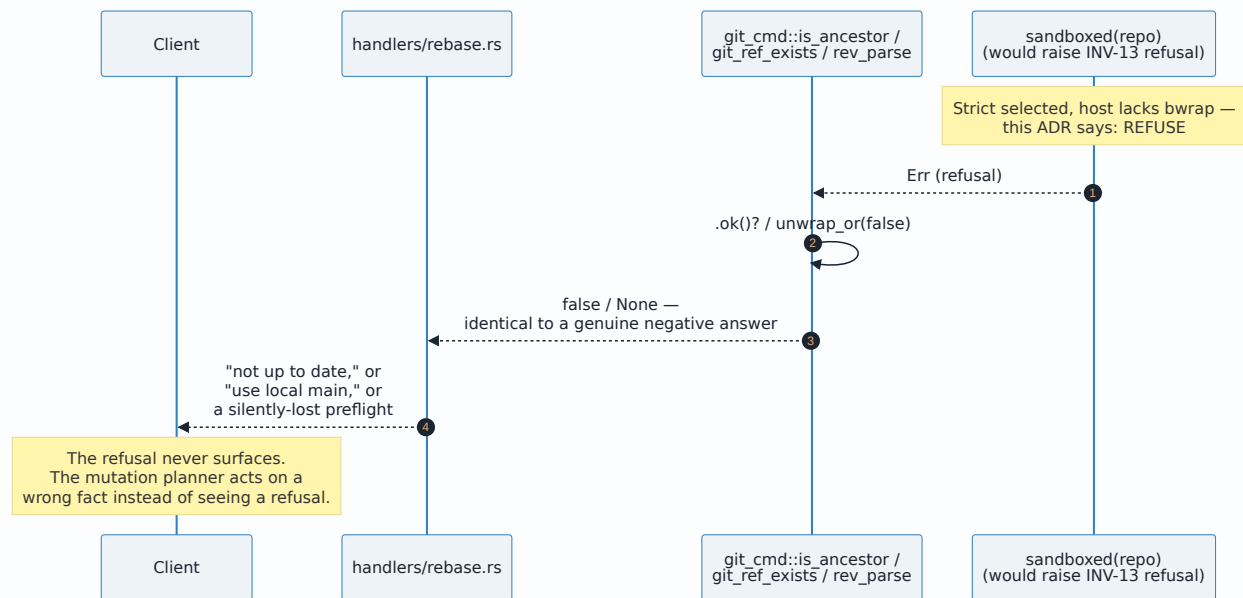
- **Branch delete loses its own undo record.** `Precondition::RefAbsent` accepts `rev_parse(...).is_none()` as satisfied (`planner.rs:539-575`, per audit), and a successful delete can journal `old_oid: None` (`planner.rs:1456-1489`, per audit) — which means `UndoAction::RestoreBranch` cannot be produced (`crates/git-vista-core/src/activity.rs:346-374`, per audit), a silent loss of the application's own restore route.
- **Merge and rebase compare two Options.** Two independently-failed reads can be misreported as "nothing to do," and one failed read out of two can fabricate a phantom journal event (`planner.rs:1394-1428`, `:1497-1532`, per audit).

Two more swallow sites, outside `git_cmd.rs`, confirmed by direct read for this ADR:

```
// crates/git-vista-server/src/coordinator.rs:117-129
async fn absolute_git_dir(repo: &Path) -> Option<PathBuf> {
    let output = tokio::process::Command::new("git")
        .arg("-C")
        .arg(repo)
        .args(["rev-parse", "--absolute-git-dir"])
        .output()
        .await
        .ok()?;
    if !output.status.success() {
        return None;
    }
    ...
}
```

`refuse_if_git_busy` (`coordinator.rs:103-105`) calls this and returns `None` — "not busy" — on the identical failure that a Strict-tier refusal would raise, silently disappearing the git-busy preflight (ADR 0019's own serialization guarantee) rather than surfacing "I don't know."


```
// crates/git-vista-server/src/planner.rs, worktree_status (per C12, ~485-492)
// uses run_git(...).await.ok()?, then generation_token's unwrap_or_default()
// (planner.rs:394-408) folds that into an empty generation field – repeated
// failures can compare equal and let staleness checks pass.
```

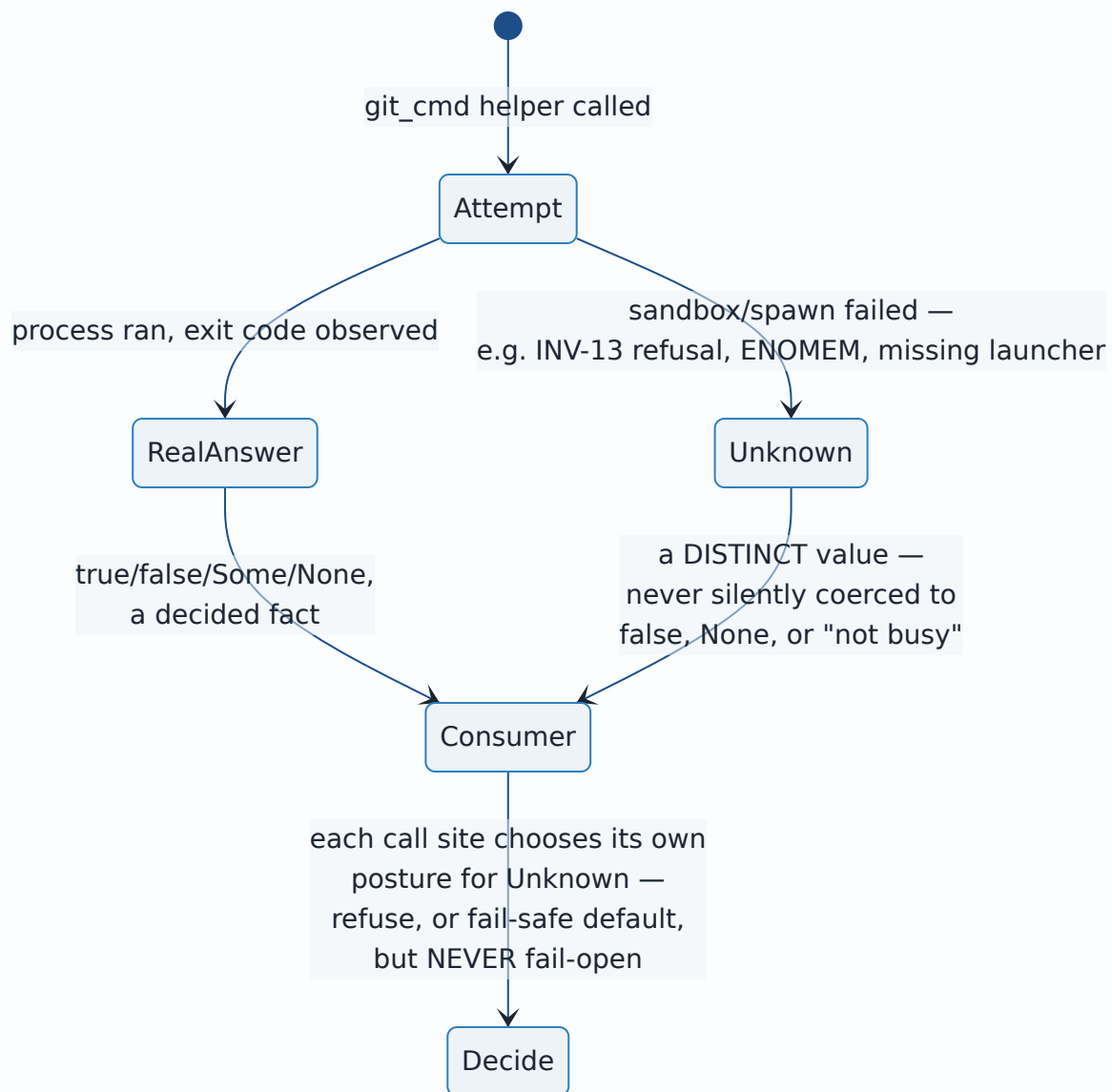


This is the audit's central point, restated plainly: **on a host without bwrap, the server would not currently refuse anything.** `is_ancestor` → `false` reads as "a rebase onto this base would change something, proceed." `git_ref_exists` → `false` reads as "the remote-tracking ref is absent, use local `main`." Two wrong answers, not two refusals, feed the mutation planner. Declaring INV-13 as hard-fail without touching these call sites would make the words true at the boundary that raises the error and false everywhere the error is consumed.

The response this ADR adopts: one explicit "unknown observation" posture

The fix is not to rename `false / None` to some other default at each of the ~22 sites above — C12 explicitly warns against exactly that ("do not merely rename `false / None` to another default"), and 20 individually-reasoned call sites are 20 chances to relauncher "unknown" into "fact" again, differently, at each site.

Instead: the planner needs **one explicit representation of "I don't know,"** distinct from every real answer it could otherwise return, threaded through from the point a sandbox/spawn failure occurs to every consumer, so a consumer must choose what "unknown" means for its own precondition rather than receiving a `false` or `None` that already looks like a decided fact.



This is deliberately a design direction, not a completed migration: Tasks 8, 9, and the `git_cmd / coordinator / planner` follow-on work are where the 20 `rev_parse` call sites, the two `is_ancestor / git_ref_exists` callers, and the two additional swallow sites actually get this treatment. What this ADR fixes is the *posture* — hard-fail at the boundary, and no site downstream of that boundary is permitted to treat "unknown" as a decided fact — ahead of that code existing, the same way ADR 0027 fixed the Landlock enumeration mechanism ahead of the shim that implements it.

Where the plan still disagrees with this ADR

Recorded plainly, because a decision record that does not name where the code (or, here, the plan text describing not-yet-written code) still disagrees with it is only half a record:

Plan Task 16.6's `hook_policy_for_repo` (`docs/superpowers/plans/2026-07-28-m1.13b-sandbox.md:4915-4923`) currently reads:

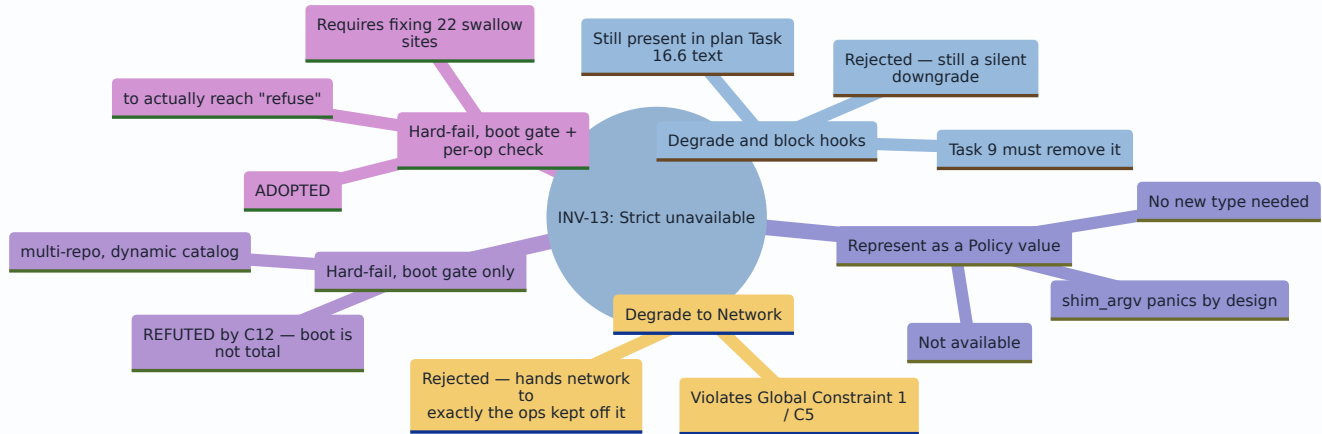
```
probe::ProbeVerdict::CapabilityAbsent { .. } | probe::ProbeVerdict::FailOpen { .. } => HookPolicy::
```

This maps a capability-absent host to "run the operation, but block hooks" — the degrade-and-block-hooks posture this ADR rejects by name. The plan's own text already flags this at lines 3344-3352 as a consequence Task 16's edit needs to resolve, not this one — quoted above under "Degrade and block hooks." This ADR is the record that INV-13 does not leave that mapping a live option: `CapabilityAbsent` for an operation that needs Strict must refuse the operation, not run it with hooks suppressed. Task 9's redesign (the boot gate plus per-operation check described above) is where this plan text gets corrected before Task 16 is built.

Consequences

- **Git-vista is unusable on a host without bubblewrap, for any operation that dispatches to the Strict tier.** Tom accepted this cost explicitly. There is no fallback mode; installing `bwrap` and enabling unprivileged user namespaces is the only path to running such an operation on that host.
- **A single boot-time capability check is necessary but not sufficient.** Task 9 must keep it, and Task 8's tier dispatch (or its policy-construction successor) must add a per-operation, per-repository check reachable from `?repo=` addressing, rescan, and clone — not only the boot-registered set.
- **The `git_cmd.rs`, `coordinator.rs`, and `planner.rs` swallow sites are now named defects, not incidental sloppiness.** They predate this ADR and are not created by it, but INV-13's hard-fail is not true in practice until they stop collapsing "the sandbox refused" into "false" or "not busy" or "no drift." This is follow-on work against Tasks 8/9, tracked here so it is not lost the way the INV-13 decision itself nearly was.
- **`hook_policy_for_repo` 's current plan text must change before Task 16 is built,** per "Where the plan still disagrees with this ADR."
- **No new type is needed to express "Strict selected, unavailable."** `shim_argv` 's existing panic already refuses to build that `Policy`; Task 8 wiring real dispatch into `policy_for_repo` needs to turn that build-time-only invariant into a request-time `Result::Err` that reaches the handler as a proper refusal, not a panic reachable from a network request.
- **This ADR does not itself change any source file.** Tasks 8, 9, and 16 are where INV-13 is implemented; this record exists so the decision Tom already took, and the gaps C12 found in the naive version of it, survive to when those tasks are built, without being re-derived — or re-broken — by whoever builds them.

Alternatives considered (summary)



Where this will be implemented

- `crates/git-vista-server/src/sandbox/capabilities.rs` — `Capabilities::strict_available()`, the existing factual probe this decision consumes.
- `crates/git-vista-server/src/sandbox/mod.rs` — `policy_for_repo`, `shim_argv`'s existing panic (to become a request-time refusal once Task 8 wires dispatch), `Tier`, `tier_for`.
- `docs/superpowers/plans/2026-07-28-m1.13b-sandbox.md` — Task 8 (tier dispatch), Task 9 (the boot probe and `ProbeVerdict`, INV-13/Global Constraint 15's boot-gate half), Task 16 (`hook_policy_for_repo`, to be corrected per "Where the plan still disagrees with this ADR").
- `crates/git-vista-server/src/git_cmd.rs` — `is_ancestor`, `git_ref_exists`, `rev_parse`: the swallow sites the "unknown observation" posture must reach.
- `crates/git-vista-server/src/coordinator.rs` — `absolute_git_dir`, `refuse_if_git_busy`: a further swallow site found during this decision's own verification.
- `crates/git-vista-server/src/planner.rs` — `worktree_status`, `generation_token`, and the ~14 `rev_parse` consumers enumerated by audit C12: where "unknown" currently becomes a decided-looking default.
- `docs/superpowers/evidence/2026-07-29-m1.13b-codex-C12-tier-dispatch-audit.md` — the audit this ADR responds to in full, including its six required design corrections.
- **Not yet built:** any of the above changes to `git_cmd.rs`, `coordinator.rs`, or `planner.rs`; Task 8's tier dispatch; Task 9's per-operation check alongside its boot gate; Task 16's corrected `hook_policy_for_repo`. This ADR records the decision and the shape its implementation must take, ahead of that code existing.

Signed: thomas2025 · 2026-07-29T12:50:40-04:00